CYBER SAFETY GUY

SOCIAL MEDIA FOOTPRINT:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Everything your child does online leaves a trace.
That trace is their digital footprint.
It can shape their future – for better or worse.
Here's what parents need to know.

81%
of 13–17 year olds have posted something online others could see
Pew Research (2023)

70%
of employers screen candidates online
CareerBuilder (2023)

7 YEARS
of content can be found about the average person online
Swayable (2023)

1 WHAT IT IS
The trail of information you leave behind online.

2 HOW IT WORKS
Posts, likes, shares, searches and sign-ups add up. They stay, even if you delete.

3 WHAT'S INCLUDED
Posts, photos, videos, comments, likes, searches, tags, and location data.

4 WHO CAN SEE IT
Friends, strangers, future employers, schools, and more. Sometimes anyone.

5 WHY IT MATTERS
It can affect opportunities, reputation and personal safety.

6 CONVERSATION
Talk early. Talk often. Keep it open and judgement-free.

WHAT ADDS TO THEIR DIGITAL FOOTPRINT?

What they post
Photos, videos, stories, updates.

What they engage with
Likes, shares, comments, reactions.

What others post
Tags, mentions, photos of them, check-ins.

What they search
Search history can reveal a lot about them.

What they sign up for
Apps, games, newsletters, competitions.

Where they go
Location data from apps and check-ins.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **It's hard to erase.**
Once it's online, it can stick around.

2. **It follows them.**
Their footprint can affect future jobs, college and opportunities.

3. **It can put them at risk.**
Too much sharing can impact safety and wellbeing.



BY THE NUMBERS

60%
of teens don't realise employers can see their online content
Kaspersky (2023)

35%
of deleted content can still be found online
Digital Citizen (2023)

46%
of teens have shared their location online
Pew Research (2023)

83%
of recruiters say online content can influence hiring decisions
CareerBuilder (2023)

SAFETY SETTINGS: WHAT EXISTS vs WHAT TO CHANGE

WHAT EXISTS

Privacy settings
Control who can see posts and info.

Content controls
Limit who can comment, message or tag.

Location controls
Turn off location sharing and check-ins.

Data controls
Manage ad preferences and data sharing.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set accounts to private.
- Review followers and remove anyone they don't know.
- Turn off location sharing.
- Limit past posts and who can see them.
- Check third-party apps and remove access.

STEP-BY-STEP: PROTECT THEIR FOOTPRINT

1. **Check their presence.**
Search their name together. See what comes up.
2. **Review privacy settings.**
Make accounts private and limit sharing.
3. **Limit what they share.**
Think before posting. Less is more.
4. **Think about tags.**
Control who can tag them and what gets shared.
5. **Clean up regularly.**
Delete old posts and unwanted content.
6. **Keep it going.**
Revisit settings and have regular chats.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

Oversharing
Too much info can put them at risk.

Identity theft
Personal details can be misused.

Reputation damage
Old posts can cause future problems.

Cyberbullying
Hurtful content can follow them.

Scams and grooming
Strangers can use info to build trust.

Missed opportunities
A negative footprint can close doors.



THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- What do you enjoy most about social media?
- What do you think people can learn about you from your posts?
- Is there anything you wouldn't want a future employer or teacher to see?
- If something goes wrong online, will you come to me?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE
Connection builds safety.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Stay calm and listen.
- Take screenshots or save links.
- Note the date, time and what happened.
- Don't delete anything.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Report to the platform.
- Block the person.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Get help from school if needed.
- Contact Childline for support.

You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE
0800 1111
childline.org.uk
YOU ARE NOT ALONE
We're here for you.